STRATEGIES FOR PROFESSIONAL GROWTH (GN3001)

Week-by-Week Sneak Peek

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WEEK 1 - TEAMWORK

Together **E**veryone **A**chieves **M**ore

10 C's of Teamwork

1. **Clarity** – Everyone knows goals and roles.
2. **Commitment** – Team believes in the goals.
3. **Communication** – Share information openly.
4. **Competence** – Use each member's skills well.
5. **Collaboration** – Work together using strengths.
6. **Coordination** – Align tasks and efforts.
7. **Connection** – Build trust and support each other.
8. **Conflict Resolution** – Solve disagreements constructively.
9. **Change Management** – Adapt smoothly to changes.
10. **Continuous Improvement** – Keep improving always.

Virat - Dhoni Comical Storyline (10 Cs of Teamwork)

Virat stormed in saying,
"Mahi bhai, the team has no *Clarity*; one thinks it's practice, one thinks it's photoshoot!"

Dhoni shrugged.
"Happens."

Virat continued,
"And their *Commitment*? Someone said he'll try only if the 'vibes match' today. And *Communication* is chaos; three group chats, no one knows which is official!"

Dhoni smirked.
"Normal."

"**Their *Competence* is wild; a pacer tried bowling off-spin, and for *Collaboration*, two guys went for the same catch and knocked each other out.**
***Coordination*? One is doing drills, another is ordering momos!"**

Dhoni raised an eyebrow.
"Momos? From where?"

Virat facepalmed.
"Even their *Connection* is lost - one player asked who the opener is… and it was him.
And *Conflicts*… they fought over who brings water bottles."

Dhoni laughed.
"Classic."

Virat sighed,
"And any *Change* in plan scares them like a plot twist in a thriller."

Dhoni patted his back.
"Relax, Virat… once they settle, stick together, and *Continuously Improve*, we'll win. Just… take away their momos."

Tuckman's Model of Team Development

- **Forming –** Team meets, stays polite, uncertain, and relies on the leader.
- **Storming –** Conflicts surface as members assert opinions and challenge structure.

- **Norming –** Trust develops, conflicts settle, and the team aligns on norms.
- **Performing –** Team operates smoothly with clarity, autonomy, and high productivity.

Team types

- **Functional team** – Members from **same department**, focus on **specific function**.
- **Cross-functional team** – Members from **different departments**, focus on **common goal/project**.
- **Virtual team** – Members **work remotely**, communicate via **digital tools**.
- **Self-managed team** – **No direct supervisor**, team **manages own tasks and decisions**.

9 Belbin Team Roles

1. **Plant** – Creative idea generator; solves problems in original ways.
2. **Resource Investigator** – Explores opportunities; brings external contacts & info.
3. **Coordinator** – Clarifies goals; delegates and keeps team focused.
4. **Shaper** – Pushes the team; drives action and overcomes obstacles.
5. **Monitor Evaluator** – Logical thinker; evaluates ideas objectively.
6. **Teamworker** – Supportive, diplomatic; builds harmony in the team.
7. **Implementer** – Turns ideas into practical action; organised and reliable.
8. **Completer Finisher** – Detail-oriented; ensures high quality and deadlines.
9. **Specialist** – Provides deep, expert knowledge in a specific area.

➔ **Action/Task-Oriented Roles:** Shaper, Implementer, Complete-Finisher

➔ **People-Oriented Roles:** Teamworker, Coordinator, Resource Investigator

➔ **Thinking-Oriented Roles:** Plant, Specialist, Monitor Evaluator

Spheres of Responsibility (Personal → Team → Organization → Society)

1. **Personal** – Own behavior, skills, growth.
2. **Team/Interpersonal** – Contribution to team, relationships, collaboration.
3. **Organizational** – Role in achieving company goals, policies, ethics.
4. **Societal/Global** – Impact on community, environment, society at large.

WEEK 2 - COMMUNICATION & LISTENING SKILLS

Types of Communication

- **Inner vs Outer** – *Inner*: Thoughts, feelings, inner chatter; *Outer*: Spoken words and actions
- **Personal vs Social/Professional** – *Personal*: Self, family, friends; *Social/Professional*: Workplace, community
- **Verbal vs Non-verbal** – *Verbal*: Spoken words; *Non-verbal*: Body language, tone, gestures
- **Written vs Oral** – *Written*: Emails, reports, documents; *Oral*: Conversations, discussions
- **Internal vs External** – *Internal*: Within team/organization; *External*: Clients, vendors, other teams
- **Vertical vs Horizontal** – *Vertical*: Upward/downward communication in hierarchy; *Horizontal*: Peer-to-peer communication
- **Formal vs Informal** – *Formal*: Reports, reviews, MoMs; *Informal*: Casual chats, quick conversations

Barriers to Communication

- **Psychological Barriers**
  – Inner chatter, biases, emotions, low focus
- **Language Barriers**
  – Different languages, complex words, jargon
- **Cultural Barriers**
  – Gestures/words interpreted differently across cultures
    - ➔ **Low-Context Cultures:** Direct, clear, structured communication; say “no” openly; rely on words over gestures.
      Example: U.S., Germany – explicit messages, eye contact.

    - ➔ **High-Context Cultures:** Indirect, ambiguous communication; rely on nonverbal cues and social context; avoid saying “no” directly.
      Example: Japan, China – subtle gestures, harmony-focused interaction.

- **Organizational Barriers**
  – Hierarchy, unclear channels, structural complexity
- **Physical Barriers**
  – Noise, distance, poor acoustics, environment

10 C's of Effective Communication

1. **Clarity** – Clear message
2. **Concise** – Short and to the point
3. **Complete** – All needed info
4. **Considerate** – Audience-focused
5. **Concrete** – Specific and solid
6. **Courtesy** – Polite and respectful
7. **Correct** – Accurate and error-free
8. **Coherence** – Logical flow
9. **Consistency** – Uniform message
10. **Creativity** – Engaging and impactful

Trump - Musk 10 C's Storyline

Trump barged into Elon's office and said,
"Elon, your Mars briefing had no *Clarity*. I couldn't tell if we're going to Mars or a movie premiere."

Elon replied,
"Because you skipped the *Concise* summary and only read the long appendix."

Trump waved a giant folder.
"And where's the *Completeness*? I want ALL details. Even snack plans."

Elon sighed.
“Donald, think about the *Consideration*; the team doesn’t need speeches about ‘tremendous rockets’ every hour.”

Trump pointed dramatically,
“Your ideas need more *Concreteness*. Tell me EXACTLY how the rocket won’t explode.”

Elon smiled.
“And your feedback needs *Courtesy*. Yelling ‘Make Mars Great Again’ doesn’t count.”

Trump rolled his eyes.
“Fine. But I demand *Correctness*. Facts. Numbers. Very accurate numbers.”

Elon tapped the whiteboard.
“That’s why we need *Coherence*. Your thoughts shouldn’t jump from rockets to golf courses mid-sentence.”

Trump adjusted his tie.
“And you need *Consistency*. Stop changing the launch date every time you get a new idea!”

Elon chuckled.
“Deal, if you bring some *Creativity* that isn’t just new hat designs.”

Trump grinned:
“Elon… creative hats are the future.”

Listening Skills

Listening means quieting your mind and paying attention to tone, pace, and emotion.

- **Passive listening** is when you simply receive the message without interrupting, acknowledging gently through nods or small sounds, especially when someone is distressed.
- **Active listening** involves showing engagement, paraphrasing to confirm understanding, asking questions, and mirroring emotions.
- **Listening to the future** focuses on hearing the speaker’s hopes and goals, helping them think forward and explore possibilities.

WEEK 3 - COMMUNICATION, PRESENTATION & WRITING SKILLS

Communication in a Professional Setting

- Share input, raise issues, give feedback - reach the **right person** only.
- Keep messages **polite, short, clear, and direct**; emails should be **formal and structured**.
- With managers: give **clear updates**; with team: **set expectations**; with customers: **be precise and professional**.
- Your communication shapes your **image, organization, and career**.

Presentation Skills

- Be **structured, audience-focused, and time-conscious**.
- Use **clear explanations, familiar formats, and visual aids** (tables, graphs, schematics).
- Separate **facts from opinions**; summarize to **orient the audience and drive decisions**.

Writing Skills

- Writing influences **credit, decisions, and policy**.
- Follow **structure**: beginning (title/summary), middle (details), end (summary/future direction).
- Use **clear, concise, correct language**; define unusual terms; aim to **inform and persuade efficiently**.

WEEK 4 - LEADERSHIP LESSONS

Leadership Lessons

Lead Yourself from Within

- Uphold Your Core Values
- Know Your Spheres of Responsibility
- Exercise Your Power of Choice
- Take Responsibility/ Ownership for Yourself
- Play to Your Full Potential
- Invest in Yourself

Lead Yourself to Lead Others

- Cultivate a Growth Mindset
- Manage Your Time and Energy
- Focus on the One Thing
- Communicate Effectively & Listen Actively
- Be Emotionally Resilient
- Embrace Change
- Manage Conflict
- Delegate Effectively
- Be a collaborative leader

Lead Others to Lead Themselves

- Make Work Worthwhile and Important
- Putting Individuals in Charge of their Goals
- Cheer each other On

Howard Gardner's Multiple Intelligences (MI)

- **Spatial Intelligence:** Ability to visualize and handle space and shapes.
- **Bodily-Kinesthetic Intelligence:** Using the body skillfully to solve problems or create things.
- **Musical Intelligence:** Sensitivity to rhythm, pitch, tone, and sound patterns.
- **Linguistic Intelligence:** Strong command of words, language structure, and expression.
- **Logical-Mathematical Intelligence:** Skill in reasoning, analyzing, and understanding logical relations.
- **Interpersonal Intelligence:** Understanding others' emotions and intentions.
- **Intrapersonal Intelligence:** Awareness of one's own feelings, goals, and decisions.
- **Naturalist Intelligence:** Ability to identify and understand patterns in nature.

WEEK 5 - EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE

- **EI** = understanding and managing your emotions + reading others + staying calm + staying motivated.
- It centers on the **amygdala** (emotion center of the brain) and differs from other intelligences because it focuses on emotional reasoning.

6R Framework

1. **Recognize:** Notice your emotions as they arise.
2. **Reflect:** Pause and understand why you feel that way.
3. **Regulate:** Manage emotions to stay balanced and in control.
4. **Respond:** Choose thoughtful, constructive actions.
5. **Relate:** Use empathy to understand others' emotions.
6. **Reframe:** Shift perspective to see situations more positively and clearly.

Harry - Hermione 6Rs

Harry knocked over Hermione's books again.
Hermione sighed: **"I *Recognize* chaos… and it's you."**

Harry scratched his head: **"Give me a moment to *Reflect* on my life choices."**

Hermione pinched her temples: **"Must… *Regulate*… the urge to fix you."**

Harry raised his wand: **"I'll *Respond* by fixing everything - Reparo!"**

Hermione nodded: **"At least you *Relate* to my stress now."**

She smirked: **"Let's *Reframe* this as practice: someday you'll have kids who act exactly like you."**

Harry: "That's the true Dark Magic."

Thomas - Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument (TKI)

Thomas - Kilmann Conflict Modes - Five ways people handle conflict, based on levels of *assertiveness* and *cooperativeness*:

- **Competing** (high assertive, low cooperative) – “My way wins.”
- **Collaborating** (high assertive, high cooperative) – “Let’s win together.”
- **Compromising** (mid both) – “We both give a little.”
- **Avoiding** (low both) – “Let’s not deal with it now.”
- **Accommodating** (low assertive, high cooperative) – “Your way is fine; I’ll adjust.”

5 components of Goleman’s Emotional Intelligence (EI):

- **Self-awareness**: Knowing your emotions and triggers.
- **Self-regulation/management**: Controlling reactions and staying composed.

- **Empathy**: Understanding others' feelings.
- **Social skills**: Communicating and building relationships effectively.
- **Motivation/passion**: Driven to achieve goals with purpose and optimism.

Article Link (How to Play to Your Strengths):
Roberts2005_HowToPlayToYourStrengths.pdf

WEEK 6 - CROSS-CULTURAL UNDERSTANDING & PERSONAL GROOMING

The ***"Culture Iceberg Principle"*** says that only a small part of culture is **visible** (like food, dress, language), while the much larger part - values, beliefs, norms, attitudes - lies hidden **(invisible**) beneath the surface and actually drives behaviour and communication.

Cultural Barriers

- **Stereotyping:** Making fixed, oversimplified assumptions about a group. *Example: Assuming all engineers are socially awkward or all artists are messy.*

- **Ethnocentrism:** Believing your own culture is superior to others. *Example: A manager from Country A insists their way of doing business is superior, dismissing local methods in Country B.*

- **Patriarchalism:** A male-dominated mindset where authority and decision-making favor men. *Example: In a team meeting, only male voices are considered for leadership decisions, while women are overlooked despite having expertise.*

Dimensions of Culture

- **Individualistic vs Collectivistic:** Individual focus, personal goals *vs* group harmony, shared goals.

- **Hierarchical vs Egalitarian:** Clear power distance and respect for authority *vs* flat structure and equal voice.

- **Certainty-Oriented vs Ambiguity-Tolerant:** Preference for rules, clarity, predictability *vs* comfort with flexibility and unclear situations.

- **Time is Plenty vs Time is Scarce:** Relaxed, fluid approach to time *vs* strict schedules, punctuality, and efficiency.

Elation → Translation → Understanding → Integration (Cultural Differences)

Culture shock occurs when interacting with unfamiliar cultures, causing discomfort.

- **Elation (Honeymoon Phase):** Initial excitement when experiencing a new culture; everything feels interesting and positive.
- **Translation (Frustration Phase):** Trying to interpret unfamiliar behaviours using your own cultural lens - often leading to wrong assumptions.
- **Understanding (Adjustment Phase):** Realizing the actual meaning behind behaviours by learning the cultural context.
- **Integration (Acceptance Phase):** Adapting your communication and behaviour to fit respectfully into the new culture.

- When Harry arrived in **Japan**, he felt **elation** as his hosts greeted him with polite bows.
- He quickly attempted a **translation** in his mind: *"They must be extremely formal and distant."*
- Later, he gained **understanding** when Hermione explained, *"They bow to show respect, not distance; it's their cultural warmth."*
- Finally, he reached **integration** by adapting - he bowed back correctly, spoke more softly, and matched their communication style.

Strategies of Cultural Creativity

Quick mnemonic: **"Dogs And Cats Avoid Snow"** → **Dominance, Accommodation, Compromise, Avoidance, Synergy**

- **Cultural Dominance** – One culture imposes its values over others; minimal adaptation.
  Example: A multinational company requires all offices worldwide to follow the parent country's work schedule, ignoring local customs or holidays.

- **Accommodation** – One culture adapts partially to another while keeping core values.
  Example: An American manager adjusts meeting times to respect the Ramazan fasting schedule of employees in the Middle East but keeps the company's core reporting structure unchanged.

- **Compromise** – Both cultures make concessions to reach a workable middle ground.
  Example: A team decides on a hybrid approach where half the meetings are in-person (preferred by one culture) and half virtual (preferred by another).

- **Avoidance** – Minimizing interaction to prevent conflict or cultural friction.
  Example: Two departments with very different work styles avoid joint projects to prevent misunderstandings or clashes.

- **Synergy** – Creating new solutions by integrating strengths of all cultures; collaborative innovation.
  Example: A global marketing team combines storytelling traditions from India with analytical campaign strategies from Germany to create a highly effective, culturally-rich ad campaign.

Personal Grooming - 3Rs

- **Right Time:** Be punctual and groom appropriately for the occasion.

- **Right Dress:** Wear attire that fits the event (formal, casual, professional).

- **Right Place:** Match your look to the environment and setting.

WEEK 7 - FISCAL AND ECONOMIC SENSE

Wealth Mantra

- **Cash Inflow**: Money coming in (salary, business income, interest, dividends).
- **Cash Outflow**: Money going out (expenses, EMIs, lifestyle spending).
- **Investment Options**: Equity, mutual funds, FD, gold, real estate, bonds - each with different risk & return.
- **ROI (Return on Investment)**: Measures how much profit you earn relative to your investment; higher ROI = better performance.

Quick Finance Glossary

- Returns: Profit earned from an investment; higher returns usually mean higher risk.

- Inflation: Rising prices that reduce the value of money over time.

- Power of Compounding: Money grows on both the principal and past returns; time multiplies growth.

- **EBITDA:** Measures a company's operating performance by excluding interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortization.

- Capital Gains: Profits earned from selling assets like stocks, mutual funds, or real estate at a higher price.

- Demand-Pull Inflation: Occurs when high demand and limited supply push prices upward.

- Consumer Price Index (CPI): Tracks changes in the price of a standard basket of goods and services to measure inflation.

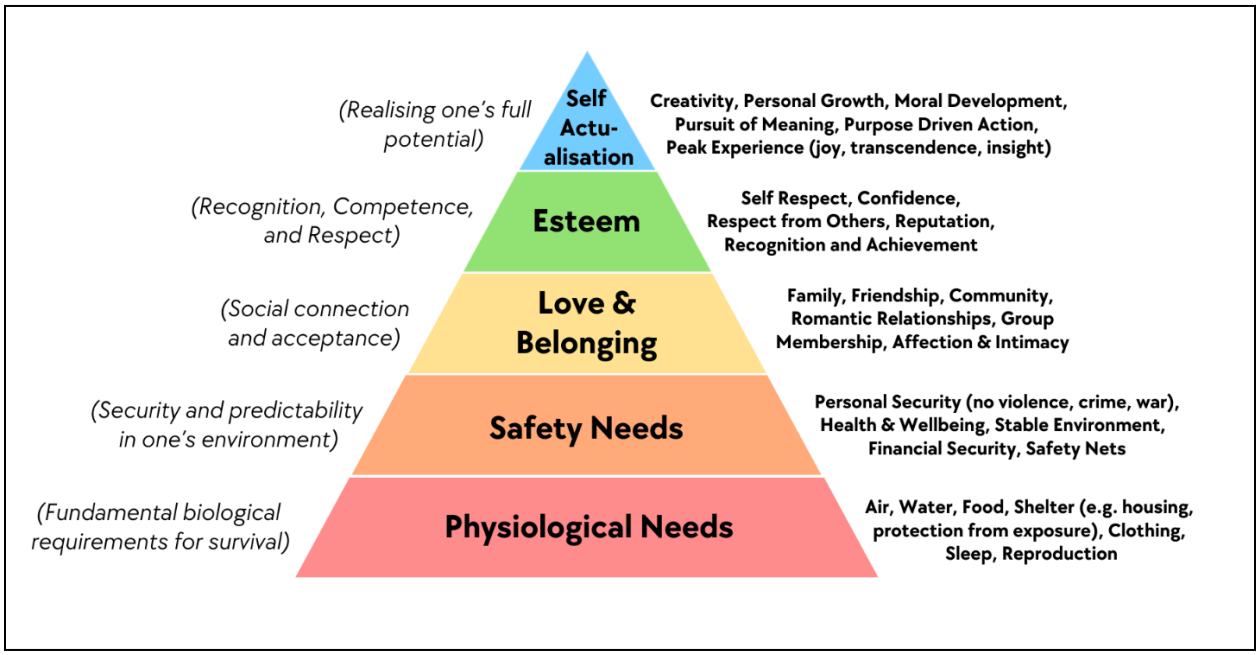
Types of Rate of Return

- **Nominal Return:** Return before adjusting for inflation or taxes.
- **Effective Return**: Actual return earned after compounding effects. *Formula:* (1 + r/n)^n − 1
- **Absolute Return**: Total return over the whole period. *Formula:* (Final − Initial) / Initial
- **CAGR (Compound Annual Growth Rate):** Smoothed annual return. *Formula:* (FV / PV)^(1/n) − 1
- **IRR (Internal Rate of Return):** Discount rate where NPV = 0. *Formula:* Solve Σ [CFt / (1 + r)^t] = 0
- **XIRR**: IRR using actual dates for irregular cash flows.
- **Tax Adjusted Return:** Return after subtracting taxes. *Formula:* Return × (1 − Tax Rate)
- **Real Return Rate:** Return adjusted for inflation. *Formula:* (1 + Nominal) / (1 + Inflation) − 1
- **Real Tax Adjusted Return Rate:** Return adjusted for both taxes and inflation. *Formula:* (1 + (Nominal × (1 − Tax Rate))) / (1 + Inflation) − 1

WEEK 8 - CREATIVITY & THINKING SKILLS

Creativity: The ability to bring into existence something new, original, or innovative; something that did not exist before.

Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs



Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs

Source: Wikipedia

Exam Tip: Try to learn the full pyramid; a ~4-5 mark(s) MCQ/short-answer question is very likely!

Key Pointers

- **Empathy:** Putting yourself in other person's shoes and looking at a problem from their point of view.
- **Attitudes for Creativity -** *Willingness to:* Be Creative, Fail, Be Wrong, See Other Perspectives, Iterate, Fall in Love with Problems
- **Anchoring:** Relying too much on the first idea or information, which can limit exploring alternatives.

- **Design Thinking:** Human-centered approach to solve problems by understanding user needs and iterating solutions (*Key Principle:* Emphasize empathy for the user)

The Process of Creativity

Mnemonic to Remember: Dumb **C**ats **R**ethink **G**reat **E**xam **I**deas
*(**D**efine, **C**ollect, **R**edefine, **G**enerate, **D**efine, **E**valuate, **I**mplement)*

- **Define the problem -** Clearly identify what issue you want to solve.
- **Collect information -** Gather data, context, constraints, and existing knowledge about the problem.
- **Redefine the problem -** Reframe or refine the problem based on new insights.
- **Generate ideas -** Brainstorm multiple possible solutions without judging them initially.
- **Define the solution -** Select and shape the most promising idea into a concrete solution.
- **Evaluate the solution -** Test feasibility, practicality, and effectiveness; refine if needed.
- **Implement the solution -** Execute the final solution in the real world.

The Creative Process in Action: Alex's Story

- Alex notices that users are struggling with an app and asks, "What exactly is going wrong here?" **[Define Problem]**
- Alex then observes users, reads feedback, and gathers data to understand the issue better. **[Collect Information]**
- After analysis, Alex realizes that the core issue is not the app itself but the small text and confusing layout. **[Redefine Problem]**
- Alex brainstorms several ideas such as larger buttons, voice guidance, and simpler navigation. **[Generate Ideas]**
- Alex selects the most practical idea and turns it into a concrete design solution. **[Define Solution]**
- The solution is tested with users, feedback is taken, and necessary improvements are made. **[Evaluate Solution]**

- Finally, the improved design is deployed, and users are able to use the app comfortably. **[Implement Solution]**

Tools for Creativity

- **Creativity Canvas:** Tools, Ideas, Process, Thinking, Belief, Imagination, Innovation, Curiosity, Motivation, Questioning, Solution,..
- **Seeking Information** through (1) Observation, (2) Listening, (3) Asking Questions, (4) Secondary Research.
- **Imagination** stimulates empathy, perspective-taking, creative expression, and dialogue.

Curiosity *(fuel for discovery, inquiry and learning)*

Characteristics of Curiosity: (1) Seeking information, (2) Asking questions, (3) Exploring alternatives, (4) Observing details, (5) Seeing what is unseen, (6) Experiencing

Four Dimensions of Curiosity:

Dimension	Description
Joyous Exploration	Pleasure in discovering and learning new things
Deprivation Sensitivity	Awareness of knowledge gaps and motivation to fill them
Openness to People's Ideas	Valuing diverse perspectives and seeking alternatives
Stress Tolerance	Comfortably handling uncertainty and discomfort during exploration

Intersections as Creative Environments *(creativity thrives where diverse ideas converge)*

Visual Metaphor: Highway intersections → meeting point of ideas

Strategies to Expand Idea Space: (1) Break associative barriers, (2) Step into intersections of different domains, (3) Explore unusual or related subjects, (4) Store questions to spark serendipity, (5) Be deliberately creative

Real-World Example: *Eastgate Centre, Harare* (inspired by termite mounds - natural ventilation, designed by Mick Pearce, example of **biomimicry** - *nature-inspired, sustainable architecture*)

WEEK 9 - CULTIVATING A GROWTH MINDSET

A. Mindset for Professional Growth

Fixed vs Growth Mindset *(Carol Dweck)*

Fixed Mindset	Growth Mindset
Avoid challenges	Embrace challenges
Give up easily	Persist through setbacks
See effort as fruitless	Effort leads to mastery
Ignore negative feedback	Learn from criticism
Threatened by others' success	Inspired by others' success

Workplace Benefits of Growth Mindset

- Higher trust among colleagues (+47%)
- Greater ownership and commitment (+34%)
- Supports risk-taking (+65%)
- Fosters innovation (+49%)

Key Insight: *People with growth mindset focus on learning and effort rather than appearing "smart."*

B. Transforming Challenges & Negative Self-Talk

Dealing with Rejection & Resistance

- Rejections ("No") and internal resistance (fear, limiting beliefs) are part of growth.
- Strategies: Fail, be curious, ask questions, iterate, and persist positively.

ABRA Method to End Negative Self-Talk (ABRA *ka* DABRA)

- **A**: **Acknowledge** limitations without fighting them
- **B**: **Breathe** in what you want
- **R**: **Release** what you don't want
- **A**: **Align** with your future self

Benefits of Failure & Imagination

- Failure is iterative learning *(Edison: "1000 ways that can cause failure")*
- Imagination + curiosity drive creative solutions

C. Positive & Abundance Mindset

- Be open, curious, and positive; practice gratitude
- Resourcefulness: leverage **internal** (talents, habits) & **external** (people, money, materials) resources
- Give back generously to create value

D. ReCREATE Your Life – 4R Framework

Step	Focus	Examples/Practices
ReCHARGE	Mind & body	Meditation, journaling, gratitude, sleep, exercise, hobbies, nature time
ReSOURCE	Potential & personal capital	Skills, strengths, values, purpose, achievements, connections
ReFRAME	Mindset & strategy	Beliefs, intentions, habits, choices, impact on others, long-term benefits
ReFOCUS	Inspired action	Clarity of goals, empowering beliefs, small wins, resourcefulness, taking action

Goal: Align actions with long-term growth, purpose, and contribution.

Pikachus' 4R Adventure:

- **Pulkit:** Naps & meditates → energizes the group [**ReCHARGE**]
- **Prashasti:** Finds tools, skills, hidden talents → equips the team [**ReSOURCE**]
- **Kshitij:** Turns obstacles into creative solutions → positive thinker [**ReFRAME**]
- **Piush:** Sets goals & guides action → keeps the team on track [**ReFOCUS**]

E. Four Zones of Growth

Zone	Description	Key Points
Comfort Zone	Familiar, low risk	Rest, recharge, but limited skill development
Fear Zone	Beyond comfort	Anxiety, limiting beliefs; manageable challenges can move you forward
Learning Zone	Stretch skills	Curiosity, calculated risks, skill acquisition; transforms into Comfort Zone over time
Growth Zone	Full potential	Embrace challenges, persist despite failure, focus on learning goals

Insight: Growth occurs outside Comfort & Fear Zones; mindset determines whether you adopt learning or fixed behaviors.

Four Zones Model

Article (Growth Mindset Case Studies - Telenor/ Microsoft/ Cigna/ Bristol-Myers Squibb):
Growth_Mindset_Case_Study_Collection.pdf

WEEK 10 - SYSTEMS THINKING

System

- Interconnected elements organized to achieve a purpose
- Three parts: **Elements, Interconnections, Purpose**
- **Heap ≠ System** (no purpose or meaningful links)

Systems Thinking

- Holistic approach: understand parts, links, and context
- Whole ≠ sum of parts
- Used to examine problems, diagnose issues, explore options, broaden perspectives

Systems View

- Everything is interconnected (resources, energy, information)
- No problem or solution exists in isolation
- Helps identify **leverage points** for intervention

Examples of Systems

- IIT Madras: students, faculty, curriculum, facilities; interacts with govt, parents, alumni
- Cricket match, food delivery, city infrastructure

Becoming a Systems Thinker

- See the **big picture** without losing details
- Expand system boundaries (size & time)
- Consider **short-term, long-term, and unintended consequences [***Good watch:* **Cats in Borneo]**
- Accept short-term pain for long-term gain
- Check results and change actions if needed (**successive approximation**)
- Observe how elements within systems change over time (identify **patterns & trends**)
- Surface and **test assumptions**

- Identify **circular nature** of cause & effect relationships
- Make **meaningful connections** across systems
- Recognize impact of **time delays** and pay attention to **accumulations**
- Change perspective to increase understanding
- Consider an **issue fully** without jumping to quick conclusions, and identify **leverage actions**
- Understand how **mental models** affect current and future realities
- Recognize that system's **structure generates behavior**

Key Insights from Case Studies

- **Rainwater Harvesting**: works only with continuous maintenance, monitoring, and collective participation

- **Workforce Deployment (WFH)**: no single best model; policies must be tested, observed, and adapted over time

Structure → Behaviour

- System behaviour is shaped by its structure (physical, policy, social)

- To change outcomes, **change the structure**

Guiding Questions

- Who else is part of this system?

- What are long-term effects of my actions?

- What unintended consequences may arise?

- What other perspectives can improve the solution?

Principles & Archetypes (Systems Thinking)

Slides Link (14 Principles & 7 Archetypes): [IMPORTANT]
Week_10_Sytems_Thinking_SPG_Shyam_Jan-Apr_2024.pdf

Exam Tip: Review the above document (Principles & Archetypes) thoroughly, ~ 8-10 marks worth of MCQs/SAs are GUARANTEED!

Article Link (Harvard's Systems Thinking):

[Restricted]Module_Note_Systems_Thinking_HBS.pdf

WEEK 11 - ENGINEERING SENSE

A. Planning & Decision Making

- Decide **what tasks to do, when to do them, and who will do them**.
- Optimize use of resources to ensure efficiency and effectiveness.
- Proper planning prevents disasters and prepares for unexpected situations.

B. Approximation & Estimation

- Enable **quick calculations** for fast and meaningful decision-making.
- Estimation provides a practical sense of quantities and supports planning.

C. Technical Auditing

- Verify processes against **plans, laws, and natural principles**.
- Ensure conformity with limits such as mass, energy, fuel, temperature, etc.
- Helps identify anomalies and deficiencies early.

D. Applying Principles

- Learning is complete only when **concepts are applied in practice**.
- Engineering principles should be used in real-life situations.
- *Example:* Applying heat transfer principles to improve factory productivity.

E. Cause & Effect / Root Cause Analysis

- Ask: *What caused this? What is the effect?*
- Repeatedly ask *why* to identify the **root cause**.
- Forms the basis of effective problem-solving and improvement.

F. Continuous Improvement

- The first version is never final; improvement is ongoing.
- Studying the history of products and processes reveals innovation opportunities.

G. Situational & Big Picture Thinking

- Understand the **current context** before making decisions.
- A solution effective in one situation may fail in another.
- Big-picture thinking helps see interconnections and multiple solutions.

H. Abstraction vs Detailing

- **Abstraction** focuses on principles and mechanisms.
- **Detailing** focuses on implementation and specifics.
- Engineers must move between both for innovation and execution.

I. Divide and Conquer

- Break complex problems into smaller functional units.
- Assign tasks, track progress, and manage complexity efficiently.
- Widely used in engineering design, project management, and programming.

J. Taxonomy, Units & Dimensions

- **Taxonomy** involves naming and classifying concepts for clarity.
- Units and dimensions give meaning to numbers and quantities.
- Essential for correct interpretation and communication in engineering.

K. Associative Understanding

- Connect ideas across different concepts.
- Leads to deeper understanding and flexible application of knowledge.

L. Crude Experimentation & Feasibility

- Test ideas using **simple or crude experimental setups**.
- Helps evaluate feasibility before large-scale implementation.

M. Core Engineering Sense Habits

- Estimation and approximation
- Reasonableness and visualization
- Abstraction ↔ detailing
- Divide and conquer
- Taxonomy
- Units and dimensions
- Associative understanding
- Crude experimentation and feasibility

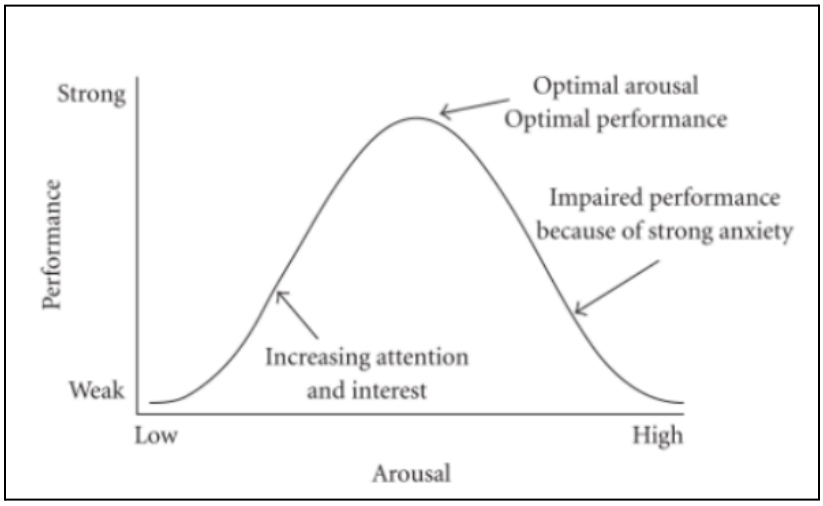
Article (Robert S. Mcnamara And the Evolution of Modern Management):
R1012G-PDF-ENG.pdf

WEEK 12 - PERSONAL & PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

(Only the portions relevant for End Term have been included)

1. Stress: Definition & Types

- **Stress** = deviation from natural balance (internal or external)
- **Good vs. Bad Stress**:
  - **Good Stress**: Motivates, challenges, improves performance
  - **Bad Stress**: Overwhelming, leads to anxiety, illness, burnout
- **Yerkes-Dodson Law** (Inverted-U):
  - *Low arousal* → weak performance
  - *Moderate arousal* → optimal performance
  - *High arousal* → impaired performance



2. Managing Energy & Well-Being

- **Energy Management**: Exercise, meditation, relaxation, nature, children, food habits
- **Build Rituals** to maintain consistency and flow
- **Well-Being Practices**:
    - **Circadian Rhythm** → align activity, rest, and meals with day/night
    - **Sleep**:
        - *10pm - 2am* → repair & regeneration
        - *2am - 6am* → deep/dream sleep (memory consolidation, organ repair)
    - **Breathing**: clears mind, reduces stress, improves oxygen
    - **Nutrition**: eat local/seasonal, avoid packaged foods, follow meal timing
    - **Exercise**: improves circulation, hormones, anti-inflammatory activity, flexibility
    - **Meditation & Reflection**: enhances focus, emotional regulation, neuroplasticity, clarity
    - **Kindness/Giving**: boosts energy, happiness, reduces stress, brings purpose

3. Time Management – 6 P's

- ➢ **Big Picture** – clarify long-term goals
- ➢ **Prepare** – organize tasks & schedule
- ➢ **Prioritize** – focus on what matters most
- ➢ **Plan** – allocate time intentionally
- ➢ **Be Productive** – minimize distractions
- ➢ **Perform** – execute efficiently

Funny mnemonic (to remember): *"Big Pandas Prefer Playing Ball Properly!"*

Individual Tips:

- ❖ Daily task lists, schedule by priority
- ❖ Tackle hardest tasks during peak alertness

4. Physical Activity & Relaxation

- Any movement reduces stress: yoga, aerobics, walking, tennis
- **Relaxation Techniques**:
  - *Autogenic relaxation* → imagery + body awareness
  - *Visualization* → calming mental scenes
  - *Progressive muscle relaxation* → tense & release muscles from toes up
  - *Tai Chi* → gentle exercise, “meditation in motion”
  - *Meditation* → focused calmness

5. Workplace Approaches

- **Work-Life Balance**: Protect downtime, balance personal & work life
- **Managerial Stress Management**:
  - **Time & Attention Management** → clarify role priorities, reduce interruptions
  - **Job Design** → skill variety, task identity/significance, autonomy, feedback
  - **Goal Setting** → specific, measurable, challenging goals aligned with objectives
  - **Job Redesign** → richer, meaningful jobs with responsibility & decision-making → reduces stress & improves motivation

Graded Assignment

WEF Future Jobs Report:
https://reports.weforum.org/docs/WEF_Future_of_Jobs_Report_2025.pdf

(Read pages 32-48; make a note of cognitive, self-efficacy, interpersonal, management and engagement skills - *the table below provides an overview of the same*)

Skill Type	Examples
Cognitive	Analytical, Creative, Technological Literacy, Systems Thinking
Self-Efficacy	Resilience, Motivation, Curiosity, Lifelong Learning
Interpersonal	Leadership, Empathy, Active Listening, Mentoring
Management	Talent Management, Resource Mgmt, Quality Control
Engagement	Service Orientation, Customer Service, Marketing

Key Insight: *Employers value **adaptable, tech-fluent, collaborative, and innovative** workers with strong self-leadership.*

Skills on the Rise (2025-2030)

- **AI & Big Data** – analytics & tech insight
- **Networks & Cybersecurity** – digital protection
- **Technological Literacy** – tech fluency
- **Creative Thinking, Curiosity & Lifelong Learning** – innovation & adaptability
- **Resilience & Leadership** – adaptive leadership

Key Insight: *Future jobs demand **adaptive, tech-savvy, and human-centric skills**.*

Tips & Strategies for Long Answer Questions

- **Identify the concept** being asked and link it to the relevant SPG content.
- Once the concept is clear (e.g., **10Cs**, **6Rs**, **EI**), **describe the framework fully**: CAPITALIZE keywords, give a brief explanation, and surround it with context from the question.
- Focus on **conceptual clarity** and grammar accuracy - that's what matters most.
- **There's no single "right answer"**; demonstrate understanding in your own words.
- It's all about **storytelling** within the prescribed word limit, and making your answer engaging and structured.
- *(If required)* **Use examples**, even 1 - 2 brief examples make your answer concrete and memorable.
- **Stay within word limit**: Be concise but complete; quality over quantity.
- **Check flow**: Ensure your answer reads smoothly and logically.
- **Stay calm and confident**: it shows in your writing and helps convey understanding.

Question:

Question 3 : 6406531337804

View Solutions (0) Total Mark : 5.00 | Type : SA

[Teaming Across Boundaries] Vikas initially felt uncomfortable with Dimitrii's work style and meeting behavior, but his perspective changed over time. Using the stages of culture shock, analyze Vikas's emotional and behavioral journey in adapting to a multicultural remote team. Answer in about 100 words.

Answer (Alphanumeric):

Answer

Discussions (0)

Sample Answer:

Vikas's journey reflects the stages of culture shock. Initially, he experienced **ELATION**, intrigued by Dimitrii's different work style but unsure how to respond. He then entered **TRANSLATION**, interpreting Dimitrii's behavior through his own cultural lens, which caused confusion and discomfort. Over time, Vikas moved to **UNDERSTANDING**, learning that Dimitrii's directness and time management were culturally influenced rather than personal. Finally, he reached **INTEGRATION**, adapting his own approach, communicating effectively, and collaborating smoothly in the multicultural remote team. This progression shows how awareness, empathy, and flexibility help navigate cultural differences and build productive cross-cultural relationships.

How to Answer Case Study Questions

• Read the case carefully, and understand the problem, stakeholders, and context.

• Identify the **core issue** – e.g., team resistance, skill gaps, technology adoption.

• Map relevant concepts:

- **Teamwork** – Belbin Roles, coordination strategies
- **Communication** – Feedback, active listening, conflict resolution
- **Leadership** – Situational or adaptive leadership, influencing
- **Emotional Intelligence** – Empathy, self-awareness, relationship management
- **Conflict Management** – Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Modes (Collaborating, Compromising)

• Evaluate solutions – consider short- and long-term impacts.

• Select the most effective solution.

• Justify your choice using **<u>theory, frameworks, or examples</u>**.

• Keep answer structured: 1–2 sentences for issue, 3–4 for solution + reasoning, 1 sentence conclusion.

Question:

[Case] When he graduated with his honours undergraduate degree in business, Dhruv was hired as a marketing associate for a large consumer products firm. Within 16 months, he was transferred to another group and promoted to the position of supervisor. About a third of Dhruv's direct reports were 10 or more years older than he was, and they seemed less than pleased when he was introduced as their new supervisor. While he was able to build respectful and supportive relationships with many of the younger employees, the older group remained aloof. Four months into his new job, Dhruv was informed that his group would be upgraded to a new project management and database system and was asked to send all his employees to training. Dhruv took the training himself first, and then asked his employees to sign up for the time slots that would be the most convenient for them. Members of the older group of employees were the last to sign up, saying they were in the middle of a busy season for their clients, and couldn't take the time. Then, the trainer complained to Dhruv that his employees had not paid much attention during the training, instead responding to emails on their smartphones or stepping out to take client calls. After the training, the older group of workers complained that the new system was ineffective and inferior to the old one. One person, Narendran, spoke the loudest and made the most complaints, explaining that he was speaking for the entire group of "seasoned veterans who really know what makes this business run."

What should Dhruv do?

A. Speak to Narendran privately about his obstructiveness, and warn him that if he doesn't cooperate by learning and using the new system, he will receive a written warning.

B. Do nothing about Narendran's complaints; over time, he and the other veterans will have to learn the system if they want to get good appraisals, raises and bonuses.

C. Call a meeting of the entire group and ask for feedback on the new system. Identify those individuals who are most technologically savvy and develop a plan together for getting everyone up to speed on all of the features and functions of the new system.

D. Speak to Narendran in front of the group of seasoned veterans. Explain that he appreciates Narendran's views and would like the entire group to get together regularly to exchange information and knowledge across all of the employees in the work group.

E. Get advice from his own supervisor regarding how to proceed with managing the different personalities and perspectives among his employees and how to best implement the changeover.

Sample Answer:

Answer: C and E

Dhruv should **call a meeting of the entire group to gather feedback** (C) and **seek advice from his supervisor** (E) to manage diverse perspectives effectively. The primary challenge is **resistance from older employees**, reflecting differences in experience, comfort with technology, and expectations. By engaging the team collaboratively, Dhruv demonstrates **Emotional Intelligence**, specifically **empathy** and **relationship management**, by acknowledging concerns and involving them in problem-solving. Identifying tech-savvy employees leverages **Belbin's Team Roles**, using **Resource Investigators** or **Implementers** to mentor peers, fostering peer learning and collaboration.

Seeking guidance from his supervisor aligns with **Situational Leadership**, helping Dhruv adapt his approach according to team maturity and readiness. This ensures he balances authority with support, rather than imposing top-down solutions. Such a **collaborative and guided approach** addresses the older employees' objections constructively, improves training adoption, and strengthens team cohesion.

This solution avoids the pitfalls of **avoidance** (doing nothing) or **authoritative confrontation** (publicly reprimanding Narendran), which could increase disengagement. By integrating **feedback, collaboration, and leadership guidance**, Dhruv can implement the new system effectively while maintaining trust and motivation across all team members.